that they were eager to file similar affidavits. But what man does, a regressive society can easily undo—what if the people refused to endorse these affidavits? Zinjade's organisation, Mahatma Phule Samaj Seva Mandal, had done a lot of relief work in Kolhapur's Herwad village during the floods in 2019 and 2021 and the Covid pandemic, and the goodwill led them to sarpanch Surgonda Patil, who expressed interest in bringing a resolution to ban practices that victimised widows.

Patil says the demise of many youngsters during the Covid pandemic and the uncertain future of their widows spurred him to make the move. After a sensitisation drive and some brainstorming, the Herwad gram sabha in Shirol taluka approved the landmark resolution on May 5, 2022. "Women are already reeling under the blow of losing their husbands, they don't need this added lifelong misery," notes Rekhatai Jadhav, the current Herwad sarpanch. In the past, the stigma had consigned widows to the background even at the weddings of their children since they were considered bad luck. Today, things have changed—widows like Ujjwala Vilas Shinge and Shrimanti Algonda Patil do the honours on occasions such as I-Day and crack the ceremonial coconut while launching development works.

"The younger generation is willing to accept change. Any social reform is gradual," notes deputy sarpanch Bharat Pawar. Shantabai Mirje, 59, who was widowed when she was barely out of her teens in 1985, recalls how she stayed confined to the four walls of her house for a decade before gradually venturing out. "In our times, women had little social exposure. Now, they go out to work and need to blend in, if nothing else, for their own security," she says.

THE GROUNDSWELL

Slowly but surely, the walls are finally coming down. After Herwad, Mangaon in Kolhapur's Hatkanangale taluka approved a similar resolution on May 13, 2022. (The village, incidentally, was the one that hosted the historic 'Mangaon conference' against caste discrimination and untouchability in March 1920, which was attended by the then Kolhapur ruler, Rajarshi Shahu Maharaj, and Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar, who had just returned to India from the US.)

After the resolution, the Mangaon panchayat chose widows to be the symbolic sarpanch and deputy sarpanch for a day. Villager Umesh Jog says he is hopeful that things will change in the future. "Regressive practices take time to be consigned to the dustbin of history," he reasons. Mangaon has gone one step further, and now offers cash aid of Rs 50,000 for women who wish to remarry. Women now already get Rs 11,000 worth of household goods and a sari worth Rs 3,000 for their marriage.

IN THE PAST, THE STIGMA HAD FORCED WIDOWS TO THE BACKGROUND EVEN AT THE WEDDINGS OF THEIR CHILDREN SINCE THEY WERE CONSIDERED BAD LUCK

The latest to join the reformist bandwagon was Ambap, on January 26. With a 10,000-strong population, the village had some 200 widows, across age groups. The younger lot number around 50, the survivors left behind by Covid, road accidents and other fatalities. "Nowadays, even villages have nuclear families," says Ambap sarpanch Dipti Vikasrao Mane. "So, if the husband dies, his widow must fend for herself and the children. Many women from our village, including the widows, work in nearby industrial and garment units.

RAZIA ASIF MULLA, 35

Ambap village, *Kolhapur*



"My husband died 10 years ago. I have two children and stitch clothes for a living. Around eight years ago, I decided to start selling bangles to supplement my income. But since I am a widow, many women said they do not want me to put bangles on their hands. Eventually, I had to shut down the business. This belief that widows are inauspicious is terrible"



USHA SANJEEV MANE, 53

Ambap

"My husband passed away three years ago. I was firm that I wouldn't follow these rituals, and had the support of my family. But others like me have had to face much hostility in our society"